independent identity of the Pathans. Attempts by the Afghan government to negotiate a solution with Pakistan fell through in 1959. As relations between Pakistan and Afghanistan deteriorated, Pakistan withdrew its mission from Afghanistan in 1961. However, two years later, in view of heightened tensions with India, Pakistan reconciled with Afghanistan with the intervention of the Shah of Iran.

Within Pakistan itself, those demanding Pakhtoonistan were divided. The National Awami Party led by Abdul Wali Khan sought regional autonomy for Pakhtoonistan, while other leaders, such as Mohammed Ayub Khan and Abdus Samad Achakzai, demanded independence instead. Abdul Ghaffar Khan supported autonomy but stressed the importance of Pashto and Baluchi speaking regions remaining together. Coordination between Pakhtoons and Baluchis would give Pakhtoonistan an outlet to the sea, offering a prospect attractive to landlocked Afghanistan.

When the Pakistan government launched its campaign against the Awami League in East Pakistan in March 1971, some of the Pakhtoon leaders considered it an opportunity to press their claims. The Afghanistan government, however, felt that no real movement was possible for Pakhtoonistan. In January 1972, the Pakistani leadership paid a surprise visit to Afghanistan to request the government not to step up propaganda for Pakhtoonistan. They received a non-committal response that worried them. The loss of East Pakistan in the creation of Bangladesh had created a new geo-political situation in the Indian subcontinent and Pakistan was anxious to preserve its integrity, stability and unity. This found support from the USA as well as neighbouring Iran. In May 1973, the Shah of Iran stated that Iran would not permit any further dismemberment